

COMIDA CALLEJERA

La calle boricua

Six street-food classics — fritters, turnovers, and skewers that taste like the island's sidewalks.

Mainland-tested · From the Ortiz kitchen

Hecho con corazón y sofrito · sofritostudio.com

Alcapurrias — Authentic Puerto Rican Stuffed Fritters Recipe

Alcapurrias

The ultimate Puerto Rican street food — shredded green banana and yautía fritters stuffed with seasoned ground beef.

Ingredients

- 2 green bananas
- 1 lb yautía (taro root)
- 1/4 cup vegetable oil
- 1 tablespoon salt
- 1 lb ground beef
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1/2 cup tomato sauce
- Manzanilla olives (optional)

Steps

1. Peel and grate the green bananas and yautía. Mix together in a large bowl with the oil and salt to form a soft masa (dough).
2. Cook the ground beef in a skillet with sofrito, sazón, tomato sauce, and olives until fully browned and saucy. Let cool slightly.
3. Take a handful of masa, flatten it into an oval on your palm, place a generous spoonful of filling in the center, and fold the masa over to enclose the filling. Shape into a torpedo.
4. Heat oil to 350°F in a deep pot. Carefully lower alcapurrias into the oil and fry for 5-7 minutes, turning occasionally, until golden brown all over.
5. Drain on paper towels. Serve hot with ketchup, mayo, or a hot sauce of your choice.

Bacalaítos — Authentic Puerto Rican Codfish Fritters Recipe

Bacalaitos

Salty, crispy codfish fritters that every Puerto Rican grew up eating at the beach, at parties, and from street vendors.

Ingredients

- 1 cup salt cod (bacalao) soaked overnight
- 1 cup all-purpose flour
- 1/2 cup water
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1/4 cup parsley, chopped
- 1 teaspoon baking powder
- Oil for frying

Steps

1. Drain the soaked cod and shred it finely with your fingers, removing any skin or bones.
2. In a large bowl, whisk together the flour and baking powder. Add water gradually, mixing until you have a thick but pourable batter.
3. Fold in the shredded cod, minced garlic, and chopped parsley. Season with black pepper — go easy on salt until you taste, since the cod is already salty.
4. Heat oil to 350°F in a deep skillet or pot. Drop spoonfuls of batter into the hot oil, flattening slightly.
5. Fry 2-3 minutes per side until deep golden brown. Drain on paper towels and serve hot with a squeeze of lime.

Empanadillas — Authentic Puerto Rican Beef Empanada Recipe

Empanadillas

Puerto Rico's answer to the empanada — larger, softer dough pockets stuffed with seasoned beef.

Ingredients

- 1 lb ground beef
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1/2 cup tomato sauce
- 1/4 cup olives, chopped
- 1 hard-boiled egg, chopped
- 12 discos (empanada wrappers)
- Oil for frying
- Salt to taste

Steps

1. Brown the ground beef in a skillet over medium heat, breaking it up with a spoon. Drain the fat.
2. Add sofrito, sazón, tomato sauce, olives, and chopped hard-boiled egg. Cook for 5 minutes, stirring to combine. Season with salt.
3. Transfer the filling to a plate and let it cool completely. Warm filling makes the discos hard to seal.
4. Place 2 tablespoons of filling on each disco. Fold the dough over to form a half-moon and seal the edges by pressing with a fork.
5. Heat oil to 350°F in a deep pan or fryer. Fry the empanadillas for 3-4 minutes per side until golden brown. Drain on paper towels.

Pastelillos de Carne — Puerto Rican Beef Pastry Pockets Recipe

Pastelillos

Flaky golden pastry pockets — Puerto Rico's most beloved snack with savory beef, sweet raisins, and briny alcaparrado.

Ingredients

- 1 lb ground beef
- 1/4 cup sofrito
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- 1/2 cup tomato sauce
- 1/4 cup raisins
- 2 tbsp alcaparrado
- 15 pastelillo discs (or pie crust)
- 1 egg beaten for wash

Steps

1. Brown the ground beef in a skillet, drain fat. Add sofrito, sazón, tomato sauce, raisins, and alcaparrado. Cook 5 minutes. Cool completely.
2. Place filling on each pastelillo disc, fold and seal the edges with a fork.
3. Brush each pastelillo with beaten egg wash for a golden finish.
4. Bake at 400°F for 15-18 minutes until golden brown. Serve warm.

Pinchos — Puerto Rican Grilled Skewers Recipe

Pinchos

The beach food, the party food, the 'I don't feel like cooking' food. Every kiosk has their own marinade.

Ingredients

- 1.5 lbs chicken thighs or pork
- 1/4 cup olive oil
- 3 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tbsp oregano
- 1 tbsp vinegar
- 1 packet sazón con culantro y achiote
- Salt and pepper to taste
- Wooden skewers (soaked)

Steps

1. Cut the meat into 1.5-inch chunks. Place in a bowl with olive oil, garlic, oregano, vinegar, sazón, salt, and pepper. Toss to coat. Marinate at least 1 hour.
2. Thread the marinated meat onto soaked wooden skewers, leaving a small gap between pieces.
3. Grill over medium-high heat or broil in the oven for 4-5 minutes per side until charred and cooked through.
4. Brush with garlic butter immediately after removing from heat. Serve hot.

Surullitos de Maíz — Puerto Rican Sweet Corn Fritters Recipe

Surullitos

Sweet corn fritters that are crispy outside, soft inside — a beloved fritura at barbecues and beach gatherings.

Ingredients

- 2 cups fresh corn kernels (or canned)
- 1/4 cup cornmeal
- 2 tablespoons sugar
- 1/4 cup milk
- 1 egg
- 1/2 tsp baking powder
- Pinch of salt
- Oil for frying

Steps

1. Blend the corn kernels until smooth in a blender or food processor.
2. In a bowl, mix the blended corn with cornmeal, sugar, milk, egg, baking powder, and salt until well combined.
3. Heat about 1 inch of oil in a skillet over medium heat to 350°F.
4. Drop spoonfuls of batter into the hot oil. Fry for 2-3 minutes per side until golden brown.
5. Drain on paper towels and serve warm.